

6 — Make It Hooking (the good way)

*(This is a direction from the product owner: the app **should** be hard to put down. Teens today are getting hooked on things that harm them — we want them hooked on something that grows them. This page tells the designer how to do that well.)*

Read this together with `1-look-and-feel.md`. Where a “hook” idea and the calm feeling seem to clash, the trick is almost always to make the hook **warmer and quieter**, not to drop it.

The one big idea: hook the habit, not the session

There are two different things you can pull a teen toward:

- **The session** — “keep scrolling right now, for hours.” This is what TikTok is built for.
- **The habit** — “come back every single day, spend a few good minutes, then go and live your life.”

We want the habit. A daily routine that has a happy ending brings a teen back tomorrow *and* leaves them better. A bottomless feed just wears them out until they delete the app. So we out-hook TikTok on the thing that matters (coming back daily) and we don’t try to beat it at the thing that hurts (endless scrolling).

The daily hook loop

Design the whole app around this simple loop, repeated every day:

1. **A nudge** — a warm notification, or just the habit itself: “today’s verse is waiting.”
2. **An easy action** — they open the app and the main thing is *right there*, one tap, no digging.
3. **A reward** — something good and a little bit surprising (see below).
4. **They put something in** — a streak grows, a verse is saved, a note is written. The more they invest, the more the app is worth to them, and the more they come back.

Make each step feel effortless and satisfying.

Steal these from TikTok — use them hard

All of these are good design and fully fit the app. Push them:

- **Instant value on open.** The second the app opens, today's devotional and verse are already there. No loading wall, no menus first.
- **Made for one thumb, zero friction.** Everything important is easy to reach and takes one tap.
- **Short and snackable.** A 4-minute devotional. Short clips. Small wins. Nothing feels like homework.
- **Personal.** Show content that fits this teen — their reading, their next step, their church's events.
- **Buttery motion + instant feedback.** Every tap responds immediately and feels nice. This is a huge part of why TikTok feels good, and it's 100% ours to use.
- **Surprise (variable reward).** They shouldn't know exactly what today holds — maybe a fresh verse, a short story, a challenge, a friend's encouragement, or a milestone. A little "what will today be?" pulls people back.
- **Streaks and progress.** People hate breaking a streak (that's real and powerful) — use it, but always warmly (see the rule below). Show growth: chapters read, days shown up.
- **Smart notifications.** Well-written, value-first nudges that name today's content ("Today: 'When friends change' — 4 min").

Make "done" feel amazing

This is your secret weapon. Because our experiences have a finish line, you get to give a teen a real hit of "I did it" every single day:

- A satisfying completion moment when the devotional is finished.
- The streak ticks up. A gentle, warm celebration (a leaf unfurling).
- A calm "you're done for today 🌱 — see you tomorrow."

That daily feeling of *finishing something good* is exactly what makes them come back. Chase that, not endless time-in-app.

The 3 things to avoid (because they backfire)

These aren't banned to be safe — they're banned because they **hurt the numbers and the trust**, especially with teens and their parents:

1. **No bottomless, auto-playing feed.** It hooks the session but burns teens out, and it's TikTok's home turf — we'd lose. Every part of the app gets a **finish line**. End the day's experience on a high, don't trap them in it.

2. **No public popularity contests piled on kids.** Comparison and “who got more likes” is the part of social media that hits teen mental health hardest. *(We are adding likes and reposts to community notes later — that’s fine, but keep it moderated and watched, and don’t spread popularity numbers onto profiles, friends, or streaks.)*
3. **No guilt or shame to force opens.** “You’re falling behind!” gets one open today and a muted app tomorrow. A warm pull (“today’s verse is waiting for you”) beats a guilt push every time.

The test for any “hooking” idea

Ask one question:

Does this help the teen build a good habit, or does it just trap their attention?

A streak reminder that says “keep it alive, today’s reading is waiting” → builds a habit. Keep it. An endless feed that auto-plays the next clip → traps attention. Drop it.

Same energy. Opposite result. We want the first one, turned all the way up.